



MONTHLY UPDATE

Innovation ecosystem: monthly update, August 2026

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ALGERIA · BURKINA FASO · CAMEROON · CAPE VERDE · COTE D'IVOIRE · DR CONGO · EGYPT · ERITREA ·
ESWATINI · GABON · GHANA · KENYA · LIBERIA · MALI · NIGER · NIGERIA · RWANDA · SOUTH AFRICA ·
TANZANIA · UGANDA · ZAMBIA

Algeria

The student start-up conversion scheme reports [673 start-ups, 3,949 patents and 2,339 innovative-project labels between 2022 and July 2026, against a 2030 target of 5,000 labelled products](#). It lets students convert final-year projects into start-ups or patents and is supported by a prototype-financing scheme and the country's first venture-capital fund. The ministerial order behind it is not held, neither its date nor its text.

The money attached to the President of the Republic's Prize for the best start-up [was raised by presidential decree 26-277 of 23 August 2026](#), amending article 3 of the founding decree of January. The amounts and the award cycle are set by decree rather than by a programme document.

Burkina Faso

The first Sahel Tech Innovation Challenge closed in Ouagadougou, taking 600 submitted projects from 23 African countries down to 100, then 60, then 10 finalists. First prize went to a [Burkinabe agricultural artificial-intelligence tool built to work in national languages](#). No prize value, follow-on funding or second edition is announced.

Cameroon

A domestically built platform for creating online shops was [profiled on 26 August](#), co-founded by a Cameroonian software engineer and pitched at widening access to digital markets for regional traders. No user, merchant, transaction or revenue figure is published, and the account is a founder profile in a trade outlet rather than a company disclosure.

Cape Verde

The innovation record moved to the extent that two institutions said they intend to work together. The national university and the economy ministry [are projecting a partnership on innovation, entrepreneurship and employment](#). Projected is the operative word: no scope, funding or programme accompanies it, and nothing here is yet an instrument the base can track.

Cote d'Ivoire

The ministry [launched two accelerator cohorts and a state procurement platform on 29 July](#), fifteen startups and fifteen digital small firms each accompanied for 24 months, applications closing 13 September, against a target of FCFA 5 to 10bn mobilised from banks, funds and donors.

A ten-year-old marketplace restructured on 31 August: the company [split its consumer and business activities and relaunched the consumer brand as Afrikrea, selling fashion, art and crafts internationally for African and diaspora creators with payment and delivery handled by the platform](#). No merchant count, transaction volume or revenue figure is published, and the terms of the split are not stated.

DR Congo

A government communiqué of 3 August confirmed that the [Startup Act implementing texts remain in preparation](#): four draft decrees adopted in May 2025 to operationalise the fiscal, customs and exchange advantages of the 2022 ordinance-law, none in force fifteen months on. None of the four texts is held.

Egypt

Egypt [led the continent in the first half of 2026 with US\\$327m raised, US\\$183m of it equity](#), after a 2025 in which one tracker counted US\$378.95m across 43 startups, second to Nigeria for a second year, funded ventures falling 15.7% as the average raise rose to US\$8.81m. A competing tracker's half-year figures for 2025 exceed twice that full-year total, and neither states its inclusion rules.

Eritrea

On 15 August the Ministry of Information [interviewed Shambko Apps Group, a self-organised software collective that has released five Tigrinya-language mobile applications](#) — literacy, puzzle, cultural-heritage and arithmetic tools built to the national curriculum — and set out a plan to extend them to Eritrea's eight other national languages. It is the first non-state software effort the base holds for Eritrea. No download count, distribution channel or funding source is stated, and the account is the state broadcaster's own.

Eswatini

[Digital transformation was named a priority of the Eswatini-Taiwan relationship](#) at a leaders' meeting in Taipei, with no instrument, figure or implementing agency named; the meeting's own date is not established.

Gabon

The open-innovation programme was launched on 14 July 2026 with the employers' federation, addressing a population the organisers put at 150 to 200 start-ups, with pre-selection on 24 July and a final on 4 August ([launch](#)). The final was postponed on 6 August after participating start-ups objected to how the edition was organised, and a [revised agenda published on 11 August](#) runs pitches to 24 August and moves the final to late September or early October. The same account gives the programme's first participation figures: 155 registered start-ups, 133 of which submitted against its 16 published challenges, and 66 shortlisted. The figures are the organisers' own and no laureate list or selection criteria has been published.

On 4 July, at the data-centre inauguration, the ministry and the facility's operator signed a memorandum giving ministry-supported start-ups professional hosting at preferential rates ([account](#)). No rate, eligibility list or take-up figure has been published.

The state digital incubator was not closed after all. It [has been placed under interim management](#), a deputy director general of the state holding that owns 30 per cent of its capital taking the post pending a new model, with a state takeover, conversion to a parapublic entity, absorption into the national innovation centre or supervision by the holding all under discussion; the digital economy ministry is to decide.

Ghana

Two assistive devices are [in pilot with a disability association](#) — smart glasses and an ultrasonic obstacle detector — at a target price of about GH¢2,000 and a 1,500-user target within a year.

A freight platform founded in 2023 was profiled on 19 August: it [takes booking, cost estimation, secured payment and cargo tracking, and handles customs formalities and border documentation for importers, exporters and online merchants](#). No volume, revenue or customer figure is stated, and the account is a profile rather than a filing.

Kenya

Venture funding data published on 27 July put Kenyan startups at [US\\$126m in the first half of 2026](#), third in Africa and the weakest half since early 2021, against US\$1.04bn across 2025.

Liberia

The technology summit closed on 22 July with [a Monrovia cybersecurity firm winning the national Startup World Cup on a domestic-data-custody pitch](#).

UNDP set out its contributions at the summit, adding in its own account of 3 August that its innovation hub sits under its Africa innovation platform.

Mali

A civil-society organisation [launched an application for reporting and checking online content, alongside the closing report of a digital campaign against viral falsehood which it says reached 68,885 people](#). It is aimed at young people and civil-society organisations, and funded through a Danish foreign-ministry facility with support from the ministry responsible for communication and the digital economy. No user or report-volume figure is published.

Niger

The innovation estate gained a site and not yet a hub. A university at Diffa [was selected through a competitive process to host an innovation hub under a development-bank and UN-backed youth agripreneurship programme, and the workshop validating its project document opened](#). A project document at validation is the stage before a budget: none is published, and no opening date is set.

Nigeria

A drive-to-own vehicle financier raised US\$250m at a US\$2.1bn valuation on 5 August, financing a 42,000-vehicle fleet across fourteen countries against platform earnings — making ride-hailing income the credit-scoring and repayment rail for drivers outside formal banking, a class of alternative-data underwriting no Nigerian instrument addresses. The communications regulator [leased its Digital Industrial Park and Learning Centre to Enugu State for fifteen years](#), its executive vice chairman saying that buildings alone do not create innovation; no rent, investment commitment or performance condition is stated. A [crowdsourced food-price platform reports about 2,500 users](#).

NITDA [inaugurated a Technical Working Group to build a multi-agency national regulatory sandbox](#), deliberately sector-agnostic, letting innovators test emerging technologies with several regulators at once before full market approval. It is distinct from the central bank's own sector sandbox, and no framework text, member list or timetable has been published.

Rwanda

As at 3 August the development bank is [the sole committed backer, at US\\$6m, of a venture debt fund that is not closed, with a further US\\$3m near-committed; cheques run US\\$300,000 to just under US\\$1m, uncollateralised, at 9 to 12%](#). The figures are the fund manager's own and no commitment date is given.

South Africa

The month's addition is a standing one. The small business department's [network of incubation and digital hubs](#) is now on the record, which matters because the two centres opened earlier in the year — a continental digital transformation centre established with the International Telecommunication Union, and an industry and technology centre hosted by a university — both sit on top of an existing state hub estate that the base had never described.

No hub count, spend or enterprise figure is published for any of the three, so the estate is established and its output is not. Both openings fall outside this month and are carried in the progress report.

Tanzania

The government launched [InnoIP Tanzania](#), a programme to help more than 5,000 innovators register and protect their work as intellectual property. No registration count, budget line or closing date has been published behind the target.

Uganda

Three innovation programmes were opened or closed. The ICT institute [launched the fourth and final cohort of a Japan-supported entrepreneurship programme on 22 July with 83 student innovators](#), publishing no cumulative startup, funding or job figure across the four batches. A [recurring fintech convening opened on 13 July](#). On 3 August the minister of state committed to [supporting commercialisation of innovations developed at the institute](#), with no budget, instrument, target or timeline.

The startup environment was assessed rather than funded. A continental alliance and the ICT ministry [validated a national digital entrepreneurship and innovation assessment at a Kampala workshop of public institutions, regulators, academia, entrepreneurs, hubs and support organisations, which named as priorities advancing the Startup Bill, strengthening science, technology and innovation policy, widening access to regulatory sandboxes and using public procurement to open markets to local startups](#). The assessment text is not published and no reform is dated or budgeted.

Zambia

A donor-funded accelerator began staffing up: a private hub [called for facilitators and group coaches for a twelve-month incubator running masterclasses, group coaching and access to funding for digital startups](#). No cohort size, budget or start date is stated, and the government innovation fund the base looked for is still not held.

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